Synthesis

"

"A special person can do this work forever and a good person can do it a little while, most people couldn't do it for a day."
The system prays on our compassion. They know we care about our work more than we do our own wellbeing. They know we will stay until we simply cannot do it anymore. We can't leave our patients...

"I feel trapped"
There is no way out. If I leave my patients I will feel guilty. If I leave my workers in this mess I will feel guilty. When someone leaves, people are jealous of them for getting out. This work is so important but it is killing me.

"

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"I've given up on trying to change things."
Managers are essentially powerless over real change which needs funding and policy change. Why can't we find the budget for a relief nurse whose job it is to relieve coworkers for breaks throughout the day?

"What I do at work is indescribable."
How can I feel recognized for the work that I do if no one, not even coworkers, know exactly what I go through? It leaves me feeling numb and isolated.

"I was not prepared for this."
No one officially trained me on the emotional trauma that this job causes. No one trained me on how to take care of myself on my days off so I just go numb. I'm doing the work of a therapist and social worker, losing people daily. How can anyone hold this much grief?

"

Feeling Valued

Recognition

When my work is interrupted, it makes me feel unrecognized and as if my work is unimportant.

I am so busy with administrative tasks that I hardly get to do the work I am trained for, the reason I got into this field. This leaves me feeling undervalued and disconnected from my sense of worth.

I don't feel like my voice is heard or valued in a system where decision making is top-down and communication is lacking. This builds resentment and frustration that make me feel unmotivated to advocate for change.

I feel like I have to prove myself at work to be valued by higher status coworkers and feel guilty about taking breaks.

Having to pay for parking and take a shuttle to work makes me feel undervalued and like I don't matter.

Not being able to eat at my desk with no time for breaks feels inhumane. Even though breaks are encouraged from management, no real effort is made to ensure we aren't overworking ourselves.

Systemic Issues

Healthcare is a commodity. A focus on profit creates systemic disregard for employee wellbeing.

THE VOID

Execs do not see care worker's needs as worth investing in. We are replaceable even though we work the hardest and are the most passionate.

Environment

Daily Tasks + Structures

There is no system in place to support breaks (i.e. relief nurse) and no functional formal feedback system. I have no faith in management to make changes.

I can never get all of my work done.
Too much cross over and lack of clarity on roles/duties creates a system of dysfunction, exhaustion, and frustration.

Overworking, "do the work" and "don't complain" mentality is the norm causing many to suffer in silence or develop resentment.

"Patient Centered Care" neglects the needs of care workers. Hierarchy < Holistic

Culture

Grief, Work Life Balance

When you're having a bad day, there is no where to go to express your grief this makes me want to get home ASAP.

I feel burnt out when there is no space for me to take a real break, get some peace & quiet or gather with my colleagues.

The lack of physical space, windows, and poor lighting takes a toll on my overall happiness at work.

Lack of Benefits + Funding

THE VOID

While **patient-centered care** aims to improve health outcomes, it often **neglects the well-being of healthcare workers.** In a profit-driven, hierarchical system that treats staff as disposable, the intense focus on patients comes at the cost of worker support, leading to burnout, poor recognition, and a toxic workplace culture. This imbalance ultimately undermines the quality of care for both patients and providers, highlighting the urgent need for a model that values healthcare workers as essential to sustainable, high-quality care.

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"What mental health?"
There are zero benefits for staff mental health. Hardly anyone uses the EAP. I would use a meditation app if it was provided. Two free counseling sessions is nothing and not worth it.

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"There is no time to grieve."
We have such limited space that once someone passes there is no time to grieve the loss before another person comes in or the other tasks add up. We are trying to find ways to share but nothing is really working. I wish we took more time together to process.

"I can't turn it off."
Even on my days off, I keep checking Teams to stay updated. I worry about my patients when I am at home. I can barely do laundry or get groceries, I am so exhausted. An extra day off a week would be a life saver.

"No budget for self care."
I try to bring up morale at work by creating events, special cards, and activities together but everything costs money out of pocket. There is no budget for this and I still have to do all of my work.

"

Map Legend

Nodes (Themes)

Sub Nodes

Synergies (Connections)

Summarized Insights from Field Research

The Void...